

THE SLOW ATLAS

Japan

The Complete Guide

Where to go, what to eat, and how to travel it slowly.



A SLOW ATLAS GUIDE • VOLUME II

WELCOME

Yokoso – welcome

There is nowhere quite like Japan. In one trip you can stand beneath a thousand vermilion torii, eat sushi at a seven-seat counter, soak in a mountain onsen as snow falls, and cross the world's busiest intersection – all with a courtesy and precision that feel like a kind of art. It is ancient and hyper-modern at once, and astonishingly easy to travel.

This guide is built to help you travel slowly and well: to understand the country, plan with confidence, and leave room for the unhurried afternoons that become the best memories – from your first rail-pass question to your last bowl of ramen.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- Before you go – timing, paperwork & packing
- Budget – what it really costs, with sample spends
- Destinations – Tokyo, Kyoto, Osaka & beyond
- Four ready-to-use itineraries, 7 to 14 days
- Getting around – the rail map, passes & IC cards
- Where to stay, what to eat, what to do
- Culture, etiquette, onsen & a phrasebook

HOW TO TRAVEL IT SLOWLY

- Do fewer places, more deeply – Japan rewards it.
- Sit at the counter; order what the chef suggests.
- Learn ten words; a bow and a 'sumimasen' open doors.
- Take the local train sometimes, not just the bullet.
- Build in an aimless afternoon in a single neighbourhood.
- Follow the quiet rules – they're half the magic.

LOCAL TIP

Carry a coin purse, an IC card and an empty afternoon – Japan fills the last one better than any itinerary.



PART ONE

Before you go

Timing, paperwork and packing – sorted.



IN THIS PART

When to go & festivals
Documents, health & money
What to pack

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When to go

Japan is a country of four vivid seasons — and timing is half the trip. Two windows are golden; two are quieter and cheaper.

Spring MAR – MAY	Cherry blossom (late Mar–early Apr, later up north). Mild, beautiful, busy — book months ahead.
Autumn OCT – NOV	Fiery foliage (koyo), crisp air and clear skies. The connoisseur's season, rivalling spring.
Summer JUN – AUG	Hot, humid; a rainy spell (tsuyu) in June. But festivals, fireworks and cool Hokkaido & the Alps.
Winter DEC – FEB	Cold and clear on the Pacific side; world-class snow in Hokkaido & Nagano; onsen weather; fewer crowds.

A MONTH-BY-MONTH ALMANAC

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS	MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jan	Cold, clear, dry	New Year, snow	Jul	Hot, humid	Gion Matsuri
Feb	Cold; deep snow N.	Sapporo Snow	Aug	Hottest	(Kyoto) Fireworks, Obon
Mar	Warming	Fest. Blossom begins	Sep	Warm; typhoons	Quiet shoulder
Apr	Mild, lovely	(S.) Cherry blossom	Oct	Crisp, clear	Foliage begins (N.)
May	Warm, pleasant	peak Green, fewer	Nov	Cool, superb	Autumn leaves
Jun	Rainy (tsuyu)	crowds Hydrangeas	Dec	Cold; illuminations	peak Snow, onsen

Documents, health & money

02

ENTRY & VISAS

- Many nationalities (EU, UK, US, Australia, Canada...) enter visa-free for up to 90 days — confirm your own rule before you fly.
- Passport valid for your stay; an onward/return ticket may be checked.
- Fill the online arrival/customs forms (Visit Japan Web) to speed up airports.
- No mandatory vaccines; be up to date on routine jabs.

HEALTH & SAFETY NET

- Excellent healthcare, but pricey without cover — take travel insurance.
- Tap water is safe to drink everywhere.
- Pharmacies (kusuriya) are widely stocked; bring your own prescriptions + a doctor's note for strong meds (some are restricted).
- Japan is very safe; the main hazards are natural (see §11).

MONEY

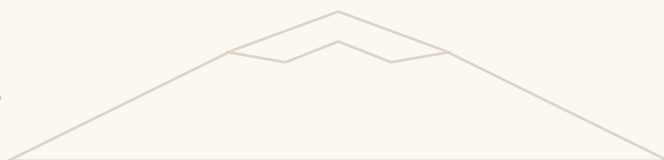
- Currency: the yen (¥ / JPY) — $\approx ¥165 = €1$ (indicative, re-check).
- Cash still matters; carry some, especially for small shops, shrines & rural areas.
- Cards & IC cards are increasingly accepted in cities.
- For cash, use 7-Eleven or Japan Post ATMs — they take foreign cards.
- No tipping — it isn't customary and can confuse.

CONNECTIVITY

- Rent a pocket Wi-Fi or load an eSIM/SIM at the airport.
- Coverage is superb nationwide; free Wi-Fi at stations & konbini.
- Google Maps works brilliantly for trains door-to-door.

LOCAL TIP

Register on 'Visit Japan Web' before you land — the QR codes for immigration and customs turn a long queue into a quick scan.



What to pack

You'll walk a great deal and take your shoes off often — pack light, comfortable and layered. Coin-laundry is everywhere, so a week's clothes is plenty.

CLOTHING

- Very comfortable walking shoes (slip-on saves time)
- Layers for changeable weather & strong A/C
- Neat-casual for nicer restaurants
- Modest cover for temples & shrines
- Season-specific: warm layers (winter), light & breathable (summer)
- A compact umbrella (sold everywhere too)

ESSENTIALS

- Clean, hole-free socks (you'll show them often!)
- A coin purse — you'll accumulate ¥ coins fast
- Power adapter (Type A/B, 100V) + power bank
- Small towel/handkerchief (many toilets lack dryers)
- Any prescriptions + doctor's note
- A foldable bag for shopping

SMART TO HAVE

- An IC-card-ready phone (mobile Suica) or a physical IC card
- Cash + a card that works at 7-Eleven ATMs
- Offline maps & a translation app
- Hand sanitiser & a few masks (still common indoors)

LOCAL TIP

Slip-on shoes are a genuine hack: you remove them at temples, ryokan, some restaurants and homes — laces get old fast.



PART TWO

Budget

What it really costs — and how it's gentler than you think.



IN THIS PART

Daily budgets, low to lavish

A sample ten-day spend

Prices to anchor on

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What Japan costs

Japan has a reputation for being expensive — but a weak yen and legendary konbini and set-lunch culture make it far gentler than most expect. Here's what to expect per person, per day, on the ground.

STYLE	PER DAY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Budget	¥8,000–12,000	Hostels/capsules, konbini & set lunches, local trains, IC card
Comfort	¥18,000–30,000	Business hotels & the odd ryokan, restaurants, some bullet trains
Luxury	¥45,000+	Ryokan & design hotels, kaiseki, reserved seats, guides

SAMPLE 10-DAY COMFORT BUDGET

ITEM	¥
Accommodation (9 nights)	120,000
Food & drink	70,000
Trains & 1 rail pass/tickets	55,000
Activities & entries	30,000
IC card, extras, buffer	25,000

≈ ¥300,000 · about €1,800 / £1,550 / \$1,950

PRICES TO ANCHOR ON

- Konbini meal: ¥400–700
- Ramen / set lunch: ¥800–1,200
- Mid restaurant dinner: ¥2,000–4,000
- Coffee: ¥400–600
- Beer: ¥400–700
- Metro ride: ¥180–320
- Tokyo–Kyoto bullet train: ¥14,000
- Temple/museum entry: ¥300–1,000
- Onsen day bath: ¥500–1,500
- Business hotel double: ¥10,000–16,000

LOCAL TIP

The set lunch (teishoku) is Japan's great value: the same kitchen that charges ¥6,000 at dinner often serves a beautiful ¥1,200 tray at noon.



PART THREE

Destinations

The unmissable places, region by region.



IN THIS PART

The lie of the land
Tokyo · Kyoto · Osaka
Which base is for you?
A short history & the arts

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The lie of the land

05

Japan is a long archipelago of four main islands. Most first trips focus on Honshu's 'Golden Route'; go deeper by adding one region.

Kanto & Tokyo

The mega-capital and its day trips: Nikko, Kamakura, Hakone & Mt Fuji.

Kansai

The cultural heart: Kyoto's temples, Osaka's food, Nara's deer, Himeji's castle.

Chubu & the Alps

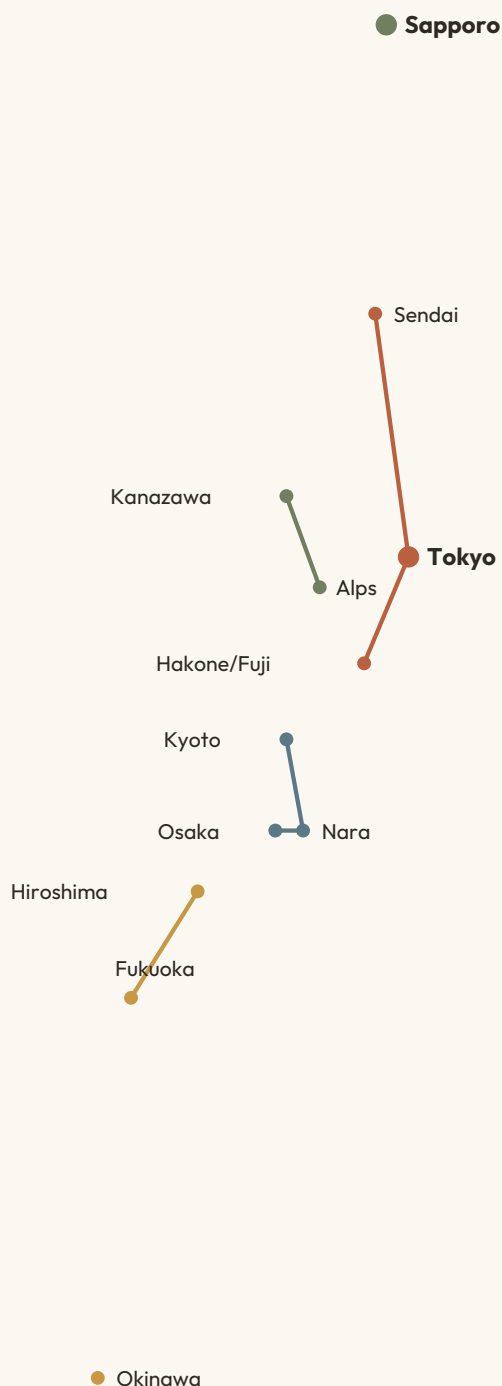
Takayama, Shirakawa-go, Kanazawa and the mountains between.

The far ends

Snowy Hokkaido, southern Kyushu, and tropical Okinawa.

INSIDER TIP

Each region has its own colour on the map opposite. First visit? Ride the Golden Route (Tokyo–Kyoto–Osaka) and add just one: the Alps, Hiroshima or Hokkaido.



Schematic – not to scale

The world's greatest city hides in plain sight: a hundred villages stitched together, each with its own temples, food and mood. Give it three or four days and it never stops giving.

DON'T MISS

- Senso-ji temple & old Asakusa
- Meiji Shrine and the youth theatre of Harajuku
- Shibuya Crossing and a skyline bar at dusk
- teamLab's immersive digital-art worlds
- Toyosu tuna auction & a sushi breakfast

EAT & DRINK

- Sushi, ramen, tempura, tonkatsu — all world-class
- An izakaya crawl down a lantern-lit yokocho
- Depachika food halls under the big stores
- The best coffee and pastry in Asia

GOOD TO KNOW

- It's a rail city — get an IC card and ride.
- Neighbourhoods are the unit: pick one per half-day.
- Superb day trips: Nikko, Kamakura, Hakone.
- Base in Shinjuku/Shibuya (buzz) or Asakusa (value).

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Two airports (Narita & Haneda); trains into town.
- JR Yamanote loop + metro cover everything.
- Walk — Tokyo is a city best read on foot.
- The bullet-train hub for the whole country.

LOCAL TIP

Base in one area per half-day — Tokyo is really a hundred villages, and dashing between them is how you miss it.



Kyoto & Nara

07

A thousand years of capital: 1,600 temples, raked-gravel gardens, geisha districts and tea. Kyoto rewards early starts and slow afternoons — and Nara's deer park is a half-hour away.

DON'T MISS

- Fushimi Inari's tunnels of vermillion torii (go at dawn)
- Kinkaku-ji, the Golden Pavilion
- Arashiyama's bamboo grove & monkey park
- Gion & Higashiyama's lantern lanes
- Nara — bowing deer & the Great Buddha of Todai-ji

EAT & DRINK

- Kaiseki, yudofu (tofu), matcha sweets & pickles
- Nishiki Market for tastes and knives
- Kyo-ryori — refined Kyoto cuisine
- A tea house for matcha and wagashi

GOOD TO KNOW

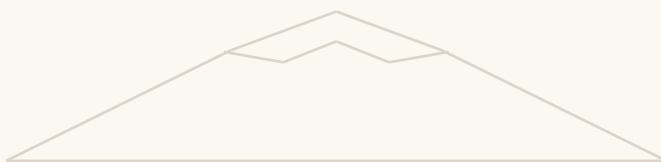
- Temples open early — beat the crowds and heat.
- Cycle or bus; buy a day pass in Kyoto.
- Autumn & blossom seasons are magical but packed.
- Save an evening for a quiet machiya dinner.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- 2h15 from Tokyo by bullet train.
- Nara: 45 min by local train.
- Compact centre; bikes are a joy here.
- A perfect base for all of Kansai.

LOCAL TIP

Kyoto's temples open early and empty; a 7am start at Fushimi Inari or the bamboo grove is a different, quieter country.



Osaka & Kansai

08

Japan's kitchen and its funniest city: brash, warm and food-obsessed, with a castle, a market and neon-drenched canals. A great-value base for the whole Kansai region.

DON'T MISS

- Dotonbori's neon, canal & giant signs
- Osaka Castle and its park
- Kuromon Ichiba market
- Kushikatsu & takoyaki in Shinsekai
- Day trips: Himeji Castle, Kobe, Koyasan

EAT & DRINK

- Takoyaki, okonomiyaki, kushikatsu — the holy trinity
- Kuromon market for seafood & fruit
- Michelin sushi to counter dives
- Highballs and yakitori under the tracks

GOOD TO KNOW

- 'Kuidaore' — eat till you drop — is the local motto.
- Cheaper hotels than Kyoto, 15 min away.
- Stand right on escalators here (opposite to Tokyo).
- Great late-night city.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- Kansai Airport (KIX) is the region's gateway.
- 20 min from Kyoto; 15 from Nara.
- Dense metro; IC card for everything.
- Bullet-train links west to Hiroshima.

LOCAL TIP

Base in Osaka to save on hotels and eat late — Kyoto and Nara are both a short train ride away.



Hiroshima, the Alps & beyond

IO

Past the Golden Route lies a quieter, deeply rewarding Japan — moving history, craft towns, thatched villages and big northern nature.

DON'T MISS

- Hiroshima's Peace Memorial Park & Museum
- Miyajima's 'floating' torii at high tide
- Kanazawa — Kenroku-en garden & gold-leaf craft
- Takayama & Shirakawa-go's thatched farmhouses
- Hokkaido's powder snow, seafood & wide-open north

EAT & DRINK

- Hiroshima-style okonomiyaki with noodles
- Kanazawa's superb sushi & gold-leaf ice cream
- Hida beef in Takayama
- Hokkaido crab, dairy & miso ramen

GOOD TO KNOW

- Hiroshima: 1h40 from Osaka by bullet train.
- The Alps reward autumn colour & winter snow.
- Hokkaido & Okinawa are quick by domestic flight.
- Regional rail passes shine out here.

GETTING THERE & AROUND

- All reachable by shinkansen or a short flight.
- Buses reach Shirakawa-go & trailheads.
- Ferries to Miyajima & the art islands.
- Consider a car for rural Hokkaido.

LOCAL TIP

One region beyond the Golden Route transforms a trip — pick the Alps, Hiroshima or Hokkaido and give it three unhurried days.



Which base for you?

You can't see it all — and you shouldn't try. Here's how the great bases compare, so you can match the trip to your mood.

BASE	VIBE	BEST FOR
Tokyo	Electric, endless, hyper-modern	First-timers, food, nightlife, day trips
Kyoto	Temples, gardens, geisha districts	Culture, walking, slow mornings
Osaka	Brash, funny, food-obsessed	Street food, nightlife, a Kansai base
Kanazawa/Alps	Craft towns & mountains	Off the Golden Route, autumn/winter
Hokkaido	Big nature, seafood, powder snow	Skiing, summer hiking, food
Okinawa	Subtropical beaches & reefs	Sun, diving, a different Japan

DID YOU KNOW?

Tokyo and Kyoto are just 2h15 apart by bullet train — close enough that many travellers base in one and day-trip freely, luggage forwarded ahead by takkyubin courier.

LOCAL TIP

Can't choose? Tokyo plus Kyoto covers most first trips beautifully — the modern and the ancient, two hours apart by bullet train.



A short history & the arts



A TIMELINE, IN BRIEF

Nara & Heian, 8th–12th c. — The imperial court, the first capitals, and 'The Tale of Genji'.

Samurai era, 12th–19th c. — Shogun rule from Kamakura to Edo; castles, tea, and Zen.

Edo, 1603–1868 — Two centuries of peace & isolation; ukiyo-e, kabuki, sushi.

Meiji, 1868 — Rapid modernisation opens Japan to the world.

Post-war to now — From reconstruction to a global capital of design, food & pop culture.

DID YOU KNOW?

Temples (o-tera) are Buddhist; shrines (jinja) are Shinto — and most Japanese happily visit both. Look for a torii gate: it marks a shrine.

HERITAGE TO SEEK OUT

- Kyoto & Nara's temples, gardens & Great Buddha.
- Himeji — the white 'egret' castle.
- Hiroshima's Peace Memorial & Miyajima's floating torii.
- Shirakawa-go's thatched farmhouses (UNESCO).
- Nikko's lavish shrines in the cedars.

THE LIVING ARTS

- Ceramics, lacquer, knives, washi paper, indigo.
- Ukiyo-e prints & the world's finest stationery.
- Anime, design & architecture (Ando, SANAA).
- Tea ceremony, ikebana & the craft of hospitality.

LOCAL TIP

Pair a temple at dawn with a design museum at noon — Japan tells its story through both its shrines and its makers.



PART FOUR

Ready-to-use itineraries

Four trips, planned for you – adapt and go.



IN THIS PART

7 days · the Golden Route

10 days · classic Japan

14 days · the grand tour

10 days · off the beaten track

THE SLOW ATLAS

7 days · The Golden Route



The classic first trip: Tokyo, the Fuji foothills, and old Kyoto & Osaka, linked by bullet train. Fly into Tokyo, out of Osaka (Kansai).

D1-3 Tokyo

Asakusa & Senso-ji, Meiji Shrine, Shibuya, teamLab and a day's wander; eat everywhere.

D4 Hakone

Onsen and Mt Fuji views; a ryokan night if you can.

D5-6 Kyoto

Fushimi Inari at dawn, Arashiyama bamboo, Gion; day-trip to Nara's deer & Great Buddha.

D7 Osaka

Dotonbori neon and street food before flying out of Kansai.

MAKE IT YOURS

Add 2-3 days and Hiroshima + Miyajima's floating torii for the 10-day version.



Schematic — not to scale

10 days · Classic Japan

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The Golden Route plus Hiroshima & Miyajima — the fullest first-timer's loop, all by rail.

D1-3 Tokyo

The capital in full, plus a day trip (Nikko or Kamakura).

D4 Hakone

Fuji, onsen, open-air art.

D5-7 Kyoto & Nara

Temples, gardens, Gion; Nara's deer and Todai-ji.

D8 Osaka

Food, castle, Kuromon market.

D9-10 Hiroshima & Miyajima

The Peace Park and the floating torii, then home.

MAKE IT YOURS

Swap Hiroshima for the Japanese Alps (Takayama & Shirakawa-go) if mountains call more than history.



Schematic — not to scale

14 days · The grand tour

13

Two weeks to go deeper: the classics plus the craft towns and mountains of the Chubu region.

D1-4 Tokyo

The capital, unhurried, with two day trips.

D5-6 Kanazawa

Kenroku-en garden, geisha & samurai districts, gold-leaf craft.

D7-8 Takayama & Shirakawa-go

Old-town mornings and thatched-roof villages in the Alps.

D9-11 Kyoto & Nara

Temples at dawn, tea, and the deer park.

D12-13 Osaka & Hiroshima

Food, then the Peace Park and Miyajima.

D14 Home

One last bowl before the airport.

MAKE IT YOURS

Travelling in winter? Swap the Alps for Hokkaido's snow and seafood, linked by a short flight.



Schematic – not to scale

10 days · Off the beaten track

14

The Japan beyond the headline sights: mountain trails, craft towns, hot springs and the slow north-west.

D1-2 Tokyo & west

Ease out of the capital toward the mountains.

D3-4 Kanazawa

Gardens, craft and superb seafood, minus the crowds.

D5-6 Takayama & Shirakawa-go

Sake breweries, morning markets, thatched villages.

D7-8 Kyoto (quiet side)

Northern temples, Ohara, an evening in a machiya.

D9-10 Kumano Kodo

Walk a stretch of the ancient pilgrim trail; onsen at Yunomine.

MAKE IT YOURS

Prefer the sea? Swap Kumano for the Setouchi art islands (Naoshima & Teshima).



Schematic — not to scale

PART FIVE

Getting around

How the country joins up – the world's best trains.



IN THIS PART

The rail network map
Shinkansen, metros & more
Passes & IC cards

THE SLOW ATLAS

The rail network

Japan runs on rails. The shinkansen (bullet train) links the big cities at up to 320 km/h – punctual to the second – while dense local lines and metros do the rest. This map shows the main high-speed spine.

LEGEND

- Tokaido-Sanyo & Tohoku shinkansen
- - - Hokuriku shinkansen
- Local JR & metro (everywhere)

RULES OF THUMB

- Tokyo-Kyoto: 2h15. Tokyo-Osaka: 2h30. Tokyo-Hiroshima: ~4h.
- Reserve a seat on busy days; non-reserved cars exist too.
- Google Maps gives exact platforms & connections.
- Stand in the marked spot – the doors stop exactly there.
- Forward luggage ahead (takkyubin) and travel light.



Getting around

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Shinkansen

The bullet train — fast, frequent, uncannily punctual. Reserve seats in peak seasons; eat an ekiben (station bento) aboard.



Local & rapid trains

Dense JR and private lines reach almost everywhere; rapid/limited-express trains cover the gaps between bullet stops.



Metro & buses

City subways are the daily workhorse; buses matter in Kyoto and rural areas. Tap an IC card and go.



Flights & ferries

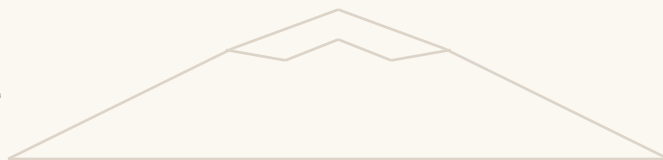
Cheap domestic flights (ANA, JAL, Peach) suit Hokkaido & Okinawa; ferries link smaller islands.

IN THE CITY

- An IC card (Suica/Pasmo/ICOCA, or mobile Suica on your phone) taps you onto every train, metro, bus and konbini.
- Stand on the correct escalator side: left in Tokyo, right in Osaka.
- Trains fall silent — no phone calls; keep bags off seats.
- Cycling is a joy in Kyoto, Kanazawa and the countryside.
- Taxis are excellent but pricey; doors open automatically.

LOCAL TIP

Put Suica or Pasmo in your phone's wallet on day one — one tap then covers every train, bus, metro and konbini in the country.



Passes & IC cards

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THE JAPAN RAIL PASS

- A nationwide pass for unlimited JR trains, including most shinkansen.
- Its price rose sharply in Oct 2023 — it's now only worth it for long, fast-moving trips (do the maths first).
- For a Golden-Route loop, point-to-point tickets are often cheaper.
- Buy online or in Japan; activate when your travel days start.

REGIONAL PASSES

- Often better value: JR-West Kansai/Hiroshima, JR-East, Hokkaido, Takayama-Hokuriku, and more.
- Match the pass to your route, not the other way round.

IC CARDS — YOUR DAILY KEY

- Suica, Pasma, ICOCA — rechargeable smart cards for trains, metros, buses, lockers and konbini.
- Simplest of all: add Suica/Pasma to your phone's wallet (mobile Suica).
- 'Welcome Suica' and mobile options cover any temporary card-supply limits — re-check availability.
- Top up with cash at any machine; tap in and out.

RESERVING & APPS

- Reserve shinkansen seats free with a pass, or via app/machine.
- Google Maps for routing; Japan Travel by Navitime for rail detail.
- Green cars = first class; worth it on long legs.

LOCAL TIP

Before buying any pass, add up your actual point-to-point fares on a fare site. Since 2023 the JR Pass rarely pays off unless you're crossing the country.



PART SIX

Where to stay & what to eat

From capsules to kaiseki.



IN THIS PART

Accommodation & ryokan

How to eat in Japan

What to order, region by region

THE SLOW ATLAS

Accommodation

Japan's lodging is a highlight in itself — from a ¥3,000 capsule to a ryokan where dinner is a fourteen-course work of art. Book the big cities and blossom/foilage season well ahead.

TYPE	¥ / NIGHT	BEST FOR
Capsule / pod hotel	¥3,000–6,000	Solo, budget, a night by the station
Business hotel	¥8,000–16,000	Clean, compact, reliable city base
Ryokan (inn)	¥15,000–50,000	Tatami, onsen, kaiseki — do it once
Machiya / design hotel	¥18,000–40,000	Character in Kyoto & the cities
Hostel	¥3,000–6,000	Backpackers, meeting people

WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

- Tokyo: Shinjuku/Shibuya (buzz) or Ueno/Asakusa (old-town, value).
- Kyoto: near Kyoto Station or in Higashiyama for temples on foot.
- Osaka: Namba/Dotonbori for food & nightlife.
- Rural: a ryokan with onsen is worth a special night.

RYOKAN KNOW-HOW

- Shoes off at the entrance; wear the yukata robe.
- Dinner & breakfast are often included — and glorious.
- Futons are laid out on tatami while you dine.
- Onsen etiquette applies (see Activities).
- Book 'half-board' ryokan a few months ahead.

LOCAL TIP

Spend one night in a ryokan with a private or public onsen — it's not just a bed but the single most Japanese experience you can book.



How to eat in Japan

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HOW IT WORKS

- Specialists rule: a shop does sushi, or ramen, or tempura — brilliantly.
- Many places have ticket machines: buy at the machine, hand the stub to the cook.
- Set lunches (teishoku) are superb value.
- Konbini (7-Eleven, Lawson, FamilyMart) food is genuinely good.
- Depachika — department-store food halls — are a wonderland.

TABLE MANNERS

- Slurping noodles is fine — even polite.
- Never stick chopsticks upright in rice, or pass food chopstick-to-chopstick (funeral rites).
- Say 'itadakimasu' before, 'gochisousama' after.
- No tipping — pay at the till, often on a small tray.

DIETARY NEEDS

- Vegetarian/vegan is growing but tricky — dashi (fish stock) hides in much. Learn 'bejitarian' and carry a card.
- Shojin ryori (Buddhist temple cuisine) is fully vegetarian.
- Halal & gluten-free options exist in big cities; ask ahead.
- Allergy cards in Japanese are invaluable.

WHAT TO DRINK

- Sake (nihonshu), shochu & superb whisky.
- Ice-cold beer; highballs in every izakaya.
- Matcha & sencha green tea; vending machines everywhere.
- 'Kanpai!' — cheers — and pour for others, not yourself.

What to order · the classics

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THE ICONS

Sushi & sashimi — at a counter, chef's choice (omakase) if you can

Ramen — shoyu, shio, miso or rich tonkotsu — slurp it hot

Tempura — feather-light battered seafood & vegetables

Tonkatsu — crisp breaded pork cutlet with shredded cabbage

Udon & soba — thick wheat vs nutty buckwheat noodles

Unagi — grilled eel glazed over rice — a summer treat

COMFORT & SHARE PLATES

Yakitori — grilled skewers, the soul of the izakaya

Okonomiyaki — savoury cabbage pancake (Osaka & Hiroshima styles)

Takoyaki — molten octopus dumplings, Osaka street food

Gyoza — pan-fried dumplings

Donburi — rice bowls — gyudon, katsudon, oyakodon

Kaiseki — the multi-course seasonal tasting menu — a splurge

LOCAL TIP

Sit at the counter whenever you can. Watching the chef work — and a quiet 'omakase' (I'll leave it to you) — turns a meal into a memory.



What to order · regions & sweets

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REGIONAL SPECIALITIES

Osaka — takoyaki, okonomiyaki, kushikatsu — 'kuidaore' (eat till you drop)

Kyoto — kaiseki, yudofu (tofu), matcha sweets, pickles

Hiroshima — its own layered okonomiyaki with noodles

Fukuoka — tonkotsu ramen & yatai street stalls

Hokkaido — seafood, crab, dairy, soup curry, miso ramen

SWEETS & SNACKS

Wagashi — delicate seasonal confections with matcha

Mochi & dango — chewy rice cakes, sweet or grilled

Taiyaki — fish-shaped cakes filled with red bean

Matcha soft-serve — everywhere, and worth it

Konbini sweets — surprisingly excellent — try the pudding

Kit-Kats — wild regional flavours — great gifts

MARKET & HALL WISDOM

- Nishiki Market (Kyoto), Kuromon (Osaka), Toyosu (Tokyo, for tuna).
- Depachika food halls at closing time discount beautiful bento.
- Follow the queue — the Japanese line up only for the very good.

LOCAL TIP

Follow the queue. The Japanese line up only for the genuinely excellent, so a long, orderly line is the surest recommendation there is.



Shopping & craft

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WHERE TO SHOP

- Depachika food halls & department stores.
- 100-yen shops (Daiso) & Don Quijote for everything.
- Konbini — snacks, socks, brilliant stationery.
- Akihabara (Tokyo) for electronics & anime; Nakamise (Asakusa) for souvenirs.
- Craft streets in Kyoto & Kanazawa.

WORTH CARRYING HOME

- Ceramics, lacquer, a good kitchen knife.
- Washi paper, tenugui cloths, incense.
- Matcha, sencha & beautiful sweets.
- Stationery — the world's best.

BUY SMART

- Tax-free: show your passport, spend ¥5,000+ at participating shops.
- Fixed prices — no haggling (it's not the culture).
- Prices are honest; quality is high; fakes are rare.
- Check voltage (100V) & region-locking on electronics.

INSIDER TIP

Omiyage — edible souvenirs, beautifully boxed — are a national ritual. A box of regional sweets is the perfect, expected gift to bring home.

LOCAL TIP

Spend ¥5,000+ at a tax-free shop with your passport to hand — the duty-free saving adds up fast across a trip.



PART SEVEN

Experiences & practical tips

What to do – and how to do it well.



IN THIS PART

Things to do & onsen

Culture & etiquette

Safety & every traveller

A Japanese phrasebook

THE SLOW ATLAS

Things to do

CULTURE & CALM

- Temple-and-shrine hop; catch one at opening, empty and still.
- A tea ceremony, or Zen meditation (zazen).
- Kabuki or sumo (seasonal tournaments).
- teamLab digital-art museums (Tokyo).
- Hanami (blossom) or koyo (autumn leaves) picnics.

ONSEN — HOW TO BATHE

- Wash and rinse thoroughly at the seated showers first.
- Bathe naked; no swimwear; tie long hair up.
- Small towel out of the water; keep quiet.
- Tattoos may be restricted — seek tattoo-friendly or private (kashikiri) baths.

NATURE & SEASONS

- Climb (or admire) Mt Fuji; hike the Kumano Kodo pilgrim trails.
- Ski or snowboard Hokkaido & Nagano's famous powder.
- The Japanese Alps: Kamikochi, Takayama, Shirakawa-go.
- Cycle the Shimanami Kaido island bridges.

CITY THRILLS

- Shibuya Crossing & a golden-hour skyline bar.
- An izakaya crawl down a lantern-lit alley (yokocho).
- Karaoke, a baseball game, a robot-era arcade.
- Day trips: Nikko, Kamakura, Nara, Hakone.

LOCAL TIP

Book the big-ticket experiences — a sumo tournament, teamLab, a kaiseki dinner — before you fly; the best ones sell out weeks ahead.



Culture & etiquette

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DO

- Bow slightly in greeting and thanks.
- Take your shoes off where you see a step up (genkan) or slippers.
- Keep quiet on trains; no phone calls.
- Queue neatly; wait for people to exit first.
- Carry your rubbish — bins are rare — and sort it.

DON'T

- Tip — it isn't done and can confuse.
- Eat or drink while walking (mostly frowned upon).
- Point with one finger, or blow your nose at the table.
- Be loud in temples, ryokan or trains.
- Stick chopsticks upright or pass food between them.

THE IDEAS BEHIND IT

So much of Japan flows from consideration for others — 'meiwaku' (avoiding causing trouble), 'omotenashi' (whole-hearted hospitality) and 'wa' (harmony). You'll rarely be corrected; simply watching and matching the people around you is the whole etiquette in one move.

TEMPLE VS SHRINE

- Shrine (Shinto): bow at the torii; rinse hands; two bows, two claps, one bow.
- Temple (Buddhist): quiet bow, no clapping; light incense.
- Photos: fine outside, often not inside halls.

LOCAL TIP

When unsure, simply watch and copy the person beside you — quiet observation is the whole of Japanese etiquette in one move.



Safety & staying well

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ONE OF THE SAFEST PLACES ON EARTH

- Violent crime is very rare; lost wallets are often returned.
- Solo and night travel are comfortable for most.
- Still: keep the usual sense in nightlife districts.
- Police boxes (koban) on many corners will help with directions.

NATURE'S HAZARDS

- Earthquakes happen — if one hits, protect your head, stay put, follow staff.
- Typhoons (Aug–Oct) can disrupt trains & flights — watch forecasts.
- Summer heat & humidity are fierce; hydrate and pace yourself.
- Download the NHK World or Safety Tips alert app.

GOOD TO KNOW

- Pharmacies are everywhere; convenience stores are 24/7.
- Coin lockers at stations swallow your bags for the day.
- Lost something? Ask staff — Japan's lost-and-found is legendary.
- Travel insurance still matters for medical costs & delays.

EMERGENCY NUMBERS

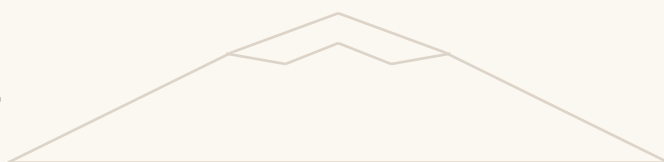
- Police 110 · Fire & ambulance 119
- Japan Visitor Hotline (24/7, English): 050-3816-2787
- Your embassy for lost passports

TRAVEL RESPONSIBLY

- Keep your voice down; don't block narrow lanes for photos.
- Never chase or touch geisha in Kyoto's Gion.
- Carry out litter; respect private streets & homes.

LOCAL TIP

Lost something on a train? Ask staff — Japan's lost-and-found is so reliable that wallets and phones routinely find their way home.



For every traveller

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SOLO & SOLO WOMEN

- Exceptionally safe and easy; night transport is fine.
- Women-only train cars run at rush hour on some lines.
- Counter dining is made for solo travellers.

ACCESSIBILITY

- Excellent overall: lifts, tactile paving, accessible shinkansen & toilets.
- Older temples & some stations still have steps.
- Reserve accessible seats in advance; staff are very helpful.

LGBTQ+

- Legal and generally safe; public displays are low-key.
- Lively scenes in Shinjuku Ni-chome (Tokyo) & Osaka.
- Same-sex marriage isn't yet national — check details for formalities.

NOMADS & BUSINESS

- Superb Wi-Fi; pocket Wi-Fi & coworking widespread; a digital-nomad visa launched in 2024 (re-check terms).
- Business: exchange cards (meishi) with both hands & a bow; bring omiyage gifts; punctuality is sacred.

LOCAL TIP

Whoever you are, Japan rewards the same approach: travel light, keep your voice low, and let the country's precision carry you.



A Japanese phrasebook · I

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ESSENTIALS

Hello — konnichiwa**Thank you** — arigatou (gozaimasu)**Excuse me / sorry** — sumimasen**Please** — onegaishimasu**Yes / No** — hai / iie**Do you speak English?** — eigo o hanasemasu ka?**I don't understand** — wakarimasen**Goodbye** — sayounara

NUMBERS

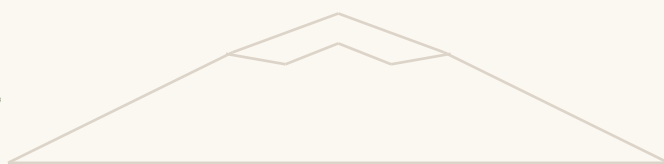
1 ichi · 2 ni · 3 san · 4 yon/shi · 5 go · 6 roku · 7
 nana/shichi · 8 hachi · 9 kyuu · 10 juu · 100 hyaku ·
 1,000 sen

GETTING AROUND

Where is...? — ...wa doko desu ka?**How much?** — ikura desu ka?**Station** — eki**Ticket** — kippu**This train to...?** — ...ni ikimasu ka?**Left / right** — hidari / migi**Straight on** — massugu**Toilet** — toire**Entrance / exit** — iriguchi / deguchi

LOCAL TIP

You don't need much Japanese — but 'sumimasen' (excuse me / sorry / thank you) is a magic word that works in almost any situation.



A Japanese phrasebook · II

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AT THE TABLE

Before eating — itadakimasu**After a meal (thanks)** — gochisousama deshita**Delicious!** — oishii!**The bill, please** — o-kaikei onegaishimasu**Water** — o-mizu**I'm vegetarian** — bejitarian desu**Cheers!** — kanpai!**I'll leave it to you** — omakase de

SMALL TALK & SHOPS

Good morning — ohayou gozaimasu**How are you?** — o-genki desu ka?**It's beautiful** — kirei desu**Can I take a photo?** — shashin ii desu ka?**Tax-free?** — menzei dekimasu ka?**Good luck / take care** — ki o tsukete

HELP

Help! — tasukete!**Hospital** — byouin**Police** — keisatsu**I'm lost** — michi ni mayoimashita

LOCAL TIP

A little Japanese, offered with a bow, is met with real warmth. Don't worry about grammar — 'sumimasen', 'arigatou' and a smile carry you a long way.



Resources & a few words

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TRUSTED & OFFICIAL

- Japan National Tourism Org — japan.travel
- Visit Japan Web (immigration/customs) — vjw-lp.digital.go.jp
- Japan Rail & fares — hyperdia / Google Maps / Navitime
- Weather & alerts — JMA; NHK World; Safety Tips app
- Tickets & tours — Klook / local sites
- Getting online — pocket Wi-Fi / eSIM providers

INSIDER TIP

Save the Japan Visitor Hotline — 050-3816-2787, English, 24/7 — for anything from lost bags to medical help.

A FEW WORDS OF JAPANESE

Hello — konnichiwa

Thank you — arigatou gozaimasu

Excuse me / sorry — sumimasen

Please — onegaishimasu

Delicious! — oishii!

How much? — ikura desu ka?

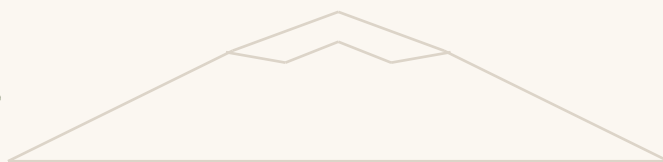
Where is...? — ...wa doko desu ka?

Cheers! — kanpai!

A bow with your thanks is always welcome.

LOCAL TIP

Bookmark the official sites before you fly — Japan's visa rules, rail-pass prices and park hours do change, and the source of truth beats a forum thread.



Before-you-go checklists

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BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ Passport valid for your stay
- ☐ Check visa-free rule (up to 90 days)
- ☐ Travel insurance (medical + delays)
- ☐ Register on Visit Japan Web
- ☐ Flights & first/last night booked
- ☐ Decide on rail pass vs point-to-point
- ☐ Pocket Wi-Fi / eSIM arranged
- ☐ IC card plan (mobile Suica?)

DAY BAG

- ☐ Coin purse + some cash
- ☐ IC card / phone wallet
- ☐ Small towel & hand sanitiser
- ☐ Umbrella; refillable bottle
- ☐ Portable charger

PACKING

- ☐ Very comfortable walking shoes (slip-on)
- ☐ Neat-casual outfit for dinners
- ☐ Clean socks (shoes come off often)
- ☐ Layers + compact umbrella
- ☐ Season gear (warm / breathable)
- ☐ Type A/B adapter + power bank
- ☐ Prescriptions + doctor's note
- ☐ Foldable shopping bag

DOCUMENTS

- ☐ Passport + copies
- ☐ Insurance details
- ☐ Booking confirmations
- ☐ Rail pass voucher (if bought)
- ☐ Allergy/dietary card in Japanese

LOCAL TIP

Screenshot this page to your phone – with Japan's queues and precise platforms, a quick pre-flight check saves real time.



Go slowly, see deeply

If there's one idea to carry into Japan, it's restraint. The travellers who fall hardest for this country are the ones who resist the checklist — who spend a whole morning in one temple garden, who return three nights to the same tiny counter until the chef nods hello, who let the local train rock them past rice fields with nowhere particular to be.

Bow a little. Learn ten words. Follow the quiet rules. Japan will meet your care with a courtesy that stays with you for years.

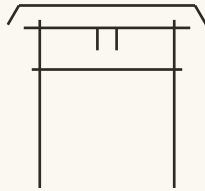
A FEW GOOD RESOURCES

- Japan National Tourism Org — japan.travel
- Visit Japan Web — for immigration & customs
- Google Maps & Navitime — for the rails
- A fare calculator — before any rail pass
- Mobile Suica / IC card — for daily travel
- Your travel insurer's 24-hour line

LOCAL TIP

Leave one day completely unplanned in a single neighbourhood. In Japan, the aimless wander down one back-street is where the magic hides.





Ki o tsukete

Take care, and travel gently.



THE SLOW ATLAS · RENNES, FRANCE